sees the goodness in people but also has an extra instinct that allows her to see flaws if any are there.

She's a nest builder and defender of her own. If you've seen a picture of a bear rearing up on its hind legs when its mate or one of its cubs is in danger, you have a pretty good idea of how Nancy responds to someone whom she thinks is trying to hurt or betray one of hers.

Although I was pleased with several of the pictures that I made as a free lance, there were two or three that I wish I hadn't said yes to—and after a while I began worrying a little about the direction my career and Hollywood in general were taking.

The turmoil set off by the Justice Department's consent decrees was still reverberating through the industry and nobody knew where it was headed. And sometimes it seemed the studios were trying to respond to the crisis by making poorer, not better, pictures.

After Nancy and I talked it over, I decided to begin turning down roles in bad pictures and holding out until something really good came along.

I went for more than a year without making a movie. Although lots of scripts were sent to me, there were not many I liked and I turned down roles that would have earned me more than $500,000. I filled the money gap by doing guest shots on television.

Our first child, Patricia Ann, had been born, and she had added lots of joy to the Reagan household. But financially, they were pretty lean and sometimes difficult times. Before I'd made the decision to say no to film offers I didn't like, we'd bought a home in the Pacific Palisades. I already owned the ranch in the San Fernando Valley where I was breeding thoroughbreds. But there was a hefty mortgage on the house and that ninety-four percent tax rate hadn't left us with a lot of savings.